

choice of devices, data backup has also become a field that has grown by leaps and bounds, and today a wide range of backup solutions in the form of software is available to the average user, which we'll encounter in later chapters. For now, let's focus on the absolute basic things to do to ensure that backups are done in an effective manner.

► Sort and prioritise

One of the major problems with backing up data is the insane amounts of data that an average user now possesses. It immediately raises the point that not all the data on your hard disk is equally important.

There are those files that are absolutely crucial to you, and then there are those that, even in case of a disaster, won't take much effort to re-attain. For example, it would be so much more painful – excruciating, in fact – to lose your private documents (photos, articles etc.), in comparison to losing that Miley Cyrus .mp3 file. So, the first thing that you should do is sort and prioritise your data. Give most importance to data that's personal, unique or



Have data backups traditionally as well as on the cloud

irreplaceable, and back them up without further ado. This is the content you want to protect no matter what – so limitations in terms of storage space or bandwidth (for cloud storage) shouldn't pose as barriers. This will also help you clean up old files that are no longer relevant to you, reducing the amount of data on disk.

Once you do this, broadly classify your data into two primary categories: critical data that needs to be backed up regularly and data that doesn't change much over time. This would eliminate the redundant task of taking unnecessary backups.

► Remove duplicates

Also, having duplicates on the same drive isn't going to be of much help. But for the one-off accidental deletion, duplicates only serve to take up extra space on your hard disk and nothing else. Therefore, installing a de-duplication software might help in removing redundant files.